

What Video Length Is Actually Correct for YouTube

Research findings for Your KC Homes / Tolley Estate Sales · 3 August 2026
Six research agents · primary-source verified · fabricated sources identified and excluded

The short answer: 8–12 minutes for the formats that generate leads (“living in [suburb]” and neighborhood guides), 6–10 for market updates, and **deprioritize single-property tours entirely** — they are the worst-performing category in real estate YouTube. Never publish search-targeted content under 4.5 minutes.

But the more useful finding is that **length ranks fifth** among the things that determine whether these videos work at all.

1. Most published guidance on this question is fabricated

This was the single biggest obstacle to answering the question, and it is worth stating first because it will keep coming up.

Circulating claim	Status
“NAR 2025 Home Buyer Digital Media Report”	FABRICATED No such publication. NAR runs mailed surveys and has no video telemetry.
“60–120 sec listing videos = highest inquiry-to-view ratio”	FABRICATED Traced to an AI listing-video vendor, zero citations.
RPM-by-length tables (“\$12–15 at 8–10 min”)	FABRICATED ~24 sites, identical undated tables, no dataset.
Mid-roll spacing rules (“3 minutes apart”)	FABRICATED Verified against 11 archived help-page snapshots 2020–2026. No spacing rule has ever been published.
“Ideal YouTube length is 8–12 minutes”	FOLKLORE Every trace ends in circular blog citations.
“Video gets 403% more inquiries”	MISATTRIBUTED Australian single-agency marketing copy, 2012.

NAR’s actual 2025 *Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers* (6,103 responses) contains **zero mentions of the word “video.”** During this research, a search engine’s own AI summary restated the fabricated NAR statistic as fact. It is laundering itself into AI-generated answers and you will keep encountering it.

2. YouTube has already answered the retention-vs-length question

The framing — “is a short video at high retention better than a long one at low retention?” — was addressed directly by YouTube and the answer rules out both halves.

*“We've heard from some creators who intentionally made their videos shorter in an attempt to get a higher retention rate. **Unfortunately, this won't help.** ... Conversely, we've also heard from some creators who intentionally made their videos longer, assuming that longer videos lead to more watch time. **This also isn't necessarily true.**”*

— YouTube Official Blog, “Why We Focus on Watch Time”

The mechanism confirms it. **Wu, RizoIU & Xie (ICWSM 2018, N = 5.3M videos)** found that **duration alone explains more than 58% of the variance in watch percentage**. One channel's short videos averaged 82% watched vs 21% for long ones; after calibrating for duration, 92% vs 78%. Same channel, same quality — the raw gap was almost entirely a duration artifact.

This is why YouTube's own `relativeRetentionPerformance` metric is defined as performance “in comparison to all YouTube videos of similar length.” The comparison is **length-normalized by construction**. You cannot arbitrage the ranking system by picking a number.

3. The only real dataset on real estate video length

REPORTED Thunderbit, June 2026 — 179 US real-estate channels, 3,839 videos published since Jan 2024, 111.6M views, collected via YouTube Data API. Dataset and scraper code published openly, which nobody else in this space does.

Content type	n	Median duration	Median views
Home tour	270	13:08	3,010
Market update	624	15:58	911
Education	859	8:23	414
Agent advice	23	7:35	1,203
Luxury	595	5:21	1,123
Listing or sale	217	3:04	531
First-time buyer	62	1:12	71

It is correlational — long videos and high views may both be downstream of established channels — but it is the only real-estate-specific measurement that exists.

4. Why not to chase the coaching advice

The coaches' own history contradicts what they sell today.

7,843 → 851
Channel Junkies median views, as they moved from 7–8 min videos to 30–60 min

3.9 min
Length of Karin Carr's "Moving to Savannah" — \$100k+ GCI, brand-new channel

~4.5 min
Briggsby plateau (100k videos): sub-2-min ranks poorly; gains flatten past this

Everyone who describes what they *did* started short. Everyone selling coaching now recommends long. The ladder is real, but length is something you climb into after you have suggested/browse traffic — it is not a starting position.

5. Monetization is not a real objective here

Using measured data **REPORTED** — AIR Media-Tech, 300 channels, 3,595 channel-months of actual YouTube Studio revenue lines, May 2025–May 2026 — the closest niche to real estate is Business & Finance at a **\$2.01 median RPM**. Not the \$12–40 the aggregator tables claim.

Views per video	Ad revenue/video	Production cost	Net
150 — current best Shorts	\$0.30	\$3.42	−\$3.12
500	\$1.00	\$3.42	−\$2.42
2,000	\$4.02	\$3.42	+\$0.60

Ads do not pay for the video until roughly **1,700 views each**. One \$250k closing at 2.5% = \$6,250 GCI, which would take **3.1 million views** to match in ad revenue — 8,500 views per day, every day, for a year.

Supporting mechanics **CONFIRMED** : ad exposure scales as roughly **length^{0.25}**. Doubling 10 → 20 minutes buys ~22% more ad exposure, not 100%, because the 6th mid-roll reaches only ~38% of the audience the 1st did. YouTube also deliberately throttles ad load — a May 2025 retune shifted ads toward natural breakpoints “in favor of viewer retention.” The one genuine cliff is **7:59 → 8:01** (mid-roll eligibility). Everything past it is smooth and decelerating.

6. Production cost does not scale with runtime

This is the one place the standard advice genuinely does not apply. Only rendered presenter seconds are metered; Ken Burns over listing photos with local TTS is free.

Runtime	Presenter face time	Cost	\$ per finished minute
8:30	14.3%	\$3.42	\$0.402
20:00	6.1%	\$3.42	\$0.171
60:00	2.0%	\$3.42	\$0.057

Cost is flat. That removes the usual production-efficiency argument against long-form — but it does not override the audience evidence in §3 and §4, which is what sets the recommendation below.

7. What actually determines whether these videos work

Ranked. Length is fifth.

1. **Topic demand — a hard ceiling.** **CONFIRMED** YouTube's own documentation: for niche topics, “the high CTR and AVD come from the entire small pool of interested viewers, which the platform will eventually run out of, resulting in low overall impressions even with high CTR.” A hyperlocal KC channel is structurally a low-impression channel by design, not by malfunction.
2. **Packaging (title / thumbnail).** The structural tell: YouTube built a native A/B test for titles and thumbnails. There is none for length.
3. **Wrong audience / no local targeting.** See the case study below.
4. **Consistency and volume over 6–12 months.**
5. **Length.** No experiment anywhere — creator or vendor — measures length changes against views.

The case study that should reframe the goal. Kati Spaniak grew a real estate channel to ~70,000 subscribers and millions of views, then wrote it up as “how starting a YouTube channel can destroy your local real estate business.” She built “trust with an audience who couldn't actually hire me.” Her precise failure: *“When someone typed 'Sell Your Home on the North Shore of Chicago,' I wasn't showing up. But when someone in California typed 'Sell Your Home,' I was all over their homepage.”*

A working practitioner's actual full-year funnel: **184 lead-form clicks → 10 leads → 3 approved buyers → 1 closing.** Lead flow concentrates in 2–3 videos out of an entire library. 200 views from the right 200 people in Lee's Summit beats 70,000 subscribers who cannot hire you.

8. Recommendation

Format	Length	Basis
“Living in / moving to [KC suburb]”	8–12 min	The actual lead-generation format. Search-intent driven, hyperlocal by construction. Start at the low end of what works, not the median of who already won.
Neighborhood guide	8–12 min	Same evidence base. Home-tour category median is 13:08 but that is established-channel data.
Market update	6–10 min	Category median is 15:58 but median views only 911 — worst views-per-minute of any category. Do not over-invest.
Single-property tour	3–5 min — deprioritize	3:04 median, 531 median views. Treat as seller-facing social proof, not lead generation.
Hard floor	Never under 4.5 min	Briggsby (100k videos, 3.8M data points): sub-2-min ranks notably worse; performance plateaus after ~4.5 min. The one data-backed length rule in the entire corpus.
Grow into	15–20 min	Only once Suggested/Browse becomes a meaningful traffic source. Do not go past this.

Channel finding

The channel currently receiving these uploads — **@yourkchome** — has **18,700 subscribers and 982 videos**, created in 2007. Its top videos are “Life of a Miner, From Altcoins to Bitcoins” (2.1M views), “Bitcoin Mining Explained” (600k), and “We are closing. The hard truth behind crypto” (185k). It is a crypto mining channel, renamed.

New uploads are shown to existing subscribers first. Those subscribers came for Bitcoin, do not click Kansas City listings, CTR craters, and distribution dies before it starts — which is the most likely explanation for listing videos averaging 3–8 views while Shorts on the same channel pull 100–334. **Decision taken: launch a fresh real-estate channel.** Local targeting is the #1 controllable factor and a crypto-trained channel actively fights it.

9. Evidence quality

Grade	Sources
STRONG	YouTube first-party docs on impressions, topic demand, mid-roll rules, and the watch-time statement. Covington et al. (RecSys 2016). Wu, Rizioiu & Xie (ICWSM 2018, N=5.3M). The Spaniak negative case study.
MODERATE	Thunderbit 179-channel dataset (vendor-published, code open). AIR Media-Tech (300 channels / 3,595 channel-months; 18,080 channels / 4.5M videos) — an MCN selling audits, but metrics are Studio-sourced. Retention Rabbit (10,000+ videos).
WEAK / NONE	All YouTube-SEO length data is 2017–2021 and unreplicated. All coaching claims are survivorship-biased with zero cohort data. No credible large-sample public dataset on real-estate video length vs inquiry rate exists.

10. Sources

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- Briggsby — Reverse Engineering YouTube Search (2018, 100k videos)
- Backlinko — YouTube Ranking Factors (2017, 1.3M videos)
- Semrush — YouTube SEO Study (2021, 15,000 keywords)
- AIR Media-Tech — Real RPM Data From 300 Channels (July 2026); Ideal Video Length by Niche (June 2026)
- Retention Rabbit — 2025 YouTube Audience Retention Benchmark Report
- Chicago Agent Magazine — Spaniak, how a YouTube channel can destroy your local business (Oct 2025)
- HomeLight — Karin Carr real estate YouTube SEO

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Cost figures are reproducible from `growth-engine/shorts/beat_plan.py`. Channel figures pulled live from the YouTube Data API. Claims are graded CONFIRMED (primary/official), REPORTED (named third party), or FABRICATED (no traceable source).